



entirely skip the stage of setting up their own website. Instead they're setting up a "page" on Facebook in order to eke out a presence on the web. Bands go to Soundcloud, most influencers hive together on Twitter, important discussions around technology and startups happen on Quora and so on...

Everything is a platform or ecosystem these days. You are given access to them for free, you can roam about within the confines of their universe but users who establish their presence on them are mere tenants not owners. You can pack up and leave but that would just mean banishing yourself to isolation. How did these big web monstrosities come about owning so much of your existence?

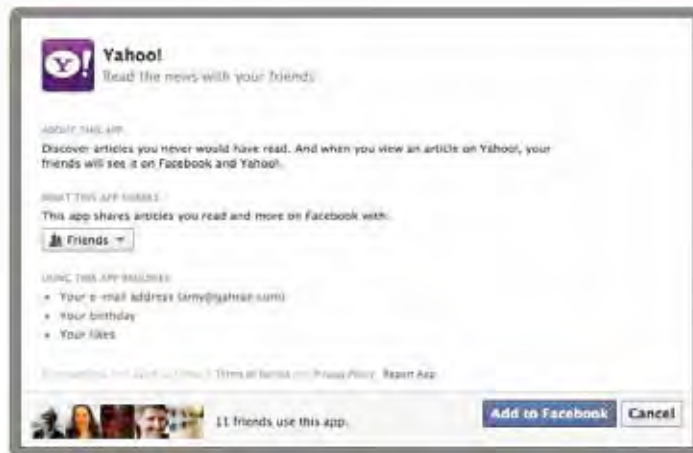
In an open market, ideas and in turn businesses follow a pattern - invention > proliferation > adoption > multiple players > consolidation and control. Take the case of ISPs in our very own (and relatively controlled) economy. Back when broadband started remember the hundreds (if not thousands) of small ISPs that mushroomed? Now the industry is pretty much in a hands of a few players. With social networks after much experimentation - multiple Orkut, Hi5s, and MySpaces later - users have settled on a few services. What is the pageviews distribution like of these big web companies? A staggering 34 percent of all page views on the web are controlled by the top 10 domains of the world - many of which are social networks. So what is so wrong with gravitating towards platforms to establish your web presence?

Lots of things....

Data mongering

It's no secret that Facebook's crazy valuation at the recent IPO was based on the fact that they have close to 900 million users. The content that these users create and the data that Facebook collects about Users,

makes up the assets side of Facebook's balance sheet. In fact some time ago the Wall Street Journal revealed a rather disturbing finding. Those little Facebook like buttons can track your activities across web pages even when you've not clicked them. As long as there is a Facebook like button on a web page you're logged in (who doesn't have a tab open with Facebook these days) it can record your activity to your account. No wonder those ads next to your timeline



No I do not want to jump through hoops just to follow a link

seem uncannily relevant right? Tracking is something Google engages in too - it's the basis of their mainstay.

Being platforms, networks like Facebook can host apps. The risks of installing dubious apps is well known but through OpenGraph apps now have the ability to call on each other for user's private data. For example, an IPL fantasy league app can tell a merchandising app that you've constantly bet on Mumbai Indians so you may want a jersey. Facebook say these and other OpenGraph implementations will help in frictionless sharing. Sure they will...

You can check out but can't ever leave

Apart from harvesting your data, the promise of the open web is under threat from another peculiar behavioral pattern that is emerging thanks to these days. For some people Google is synonymous with the web. "I saw it on Google", they'll say.

What they actually mean is that "Google led me to it". But honestly with cached screenshots and easily readable previews (not any more) there was a foreseeable scenario where you wouldn't have to leave Google at all.

Now let's look at the other web juggernaut, Facebook. On one of your many daily timeline sojourns, say you see an interesting link shared by a friend. It's an article on Yahoo news, you click it and instead of leading you to the article it throws up a notification for some news reader app. Now those of us who are averse to this sort of enforced installing of software follow this method: Highlight article title, ctrl + c, open new tab, and search on Google. The workaround notwithstanding, the idea here is to not let the user leave the Facebook environment.

Twitter and its numerous clients also pull in and embed rich content from publishers. Soon enough you won't even have to click on those links within tweets to venture outside twitter. Back when the first citizens of web (read: Americans) started logging on through their dialup AOL connections, they never had access to the open web. But soon enough those walls had to be torn down. Early netizens rebelled against the idea of any entity that forced a curated experience down their collective throats. Why then does this second generation of web babies seem so happy scurrying about within the confines of Facebook and Twitter?

Hyperlinks are the neural network of the web. Breaking them with closed apps will surely lead to an online palsy of sorts. You as a user are guilty of being happy being content in these walled gardens. You have helped changed the ethos of an essentially open system. Today thanks to you the web now stands for something that it never was: a rigid and controlled environment. **[1]**